the universal machine gun were scattered all over. There were blood stains on one of the tables. The trail of the blood stains ended in the alley from where, possibly, the injured terrorist was picked up by a vehicle. Finding nothing more, the search was called off. I led the convoy to the Division HQ at the other extreme of the town.

'Thank God, you are safe. What is your plan of action now?' asked the brigadier who was the officiating GOC. 'Sir, I would recommend a cordon-and-search of Shera village at the earliest. I am sure these b——ds have gone there, and would soon disperse,' I said, based on confidence that comes only from experience.

'Go right ahead, you have my okay,' said the officiating GOC. The cordon-and-search operations were carried out and over the next few days, we caught a few of these terrorists. I addressed the people as usual, and mockingly asked them to convey to the terrorists that they must go back and do some more training. They wasted so much of ammunition in the ambush!

Twelve years later, I was amazed when the story of this ambush was recounted by an officer whom I had never met before. During my farewell visit to 2 Corps at Ambala in December 2004 as the chief designate, a retired lieutenant colonel came up to me and said he was present in Baramulla on a holiday in 1992. He was staying with a relative whose house happened to be on the main highway, very close to the place where the terrorists ambushed me. He had heard rumours floating around about the plan the previous evening, but was scared stiff to move out or to do anything about it, like sending word to the 19 Infantry Division HQ, about half a kilometre from there. I asked him why he had kept silent for so long. 'It was due to remorse and a feeling of guilt, but I prayed for you,' he replied. He wrote a letter describing the incident which is given in Appendix 1.

While conducting another operation, one of my sub-unit commanders had an interesting experience. As Ravi (name changed) and his boys were passing by a small hamlet they noticed that someone peeped out and then closed the window. There appeared